



De Havilland biplane is
"bombed up" in 1918

Great Manufacturers De Havilland

In September 1920 the de Havilland Aircraft Company was set up at an old Royal Flying Corps base at Stag Lane, North London. Over the next 40 years the company would produce some of the most influential aircraft the world has ever seen, and also design and manufacture the engines that powered them.

ONE OF THE GREATEST names in aviation history, the de Havilland Aircraft Company built some remarkable aircraft, including record-breaking racers, the first true multirole combat aircraft, and the first jetliner. Through great triumphs and immense personal tragedy (two sons of company founder Geoffrey de Havilland died in his aircraft) it would eventually produce some of the most famous aircraft of all time.



Geoffrey de Havilland
(1882-1965)

during September the following year, and this brought de Havilland to the attention of the military and led to additional funding. The second machine, known initially as the de Havilland No2 airplane, became the FE1. In January 1911, it passed its acceptance test, and while flying it de Havilland qualified for Royal Aero Club Certificate No.4. Aviation was progressing rapidly, and in 1912 de Havilland flew another

of his designs—the BE2—at more than 10,000 ft (3,000 m), setting a new British Altitude Record. In 1914 de Havilland became Inspector of Aircraft for the Aeronautical Inspection Directorate; however, he quickly realized that the post was not for him, and he joined the Aircraft Manufacturing Company (known as Airco), as designer and test pilot. With the advent of war (and a brief spell in the Royal Flying Corps as a reservist) de Havilland began designing warplanes. Around 400 DH2 fighters were built, while the DH4 light bomber (and its successor, the DH9) were tremendous successes.

After the war ended orders dried up, and Airco was bought by Birmingham Small Arms (BSA). However, BSA only wanted Airco's Hendon premises, and had no interest in aviation. So de Havilland formed his own company, selecting the best

De Havilland hire service

An Imperial Airways poster advertises the Joint London (Croydon)–Brisbane service operated by Imperial and QANTAS.



Aerial warfare

De Havilland employees construct Mosquitos at the company's Hatfield HQ in 1944. The plane was pivotal to the Allied war effort.

De Havilland enjoyed considerable success with the Gypsy Moth and also built the famous DH88 Comet racer and the elegant DH91 Albatross. However, the continuing growth of London soon saw the Stag Lane site encircled by housing, and by 1934 aircraft production had shifted to Hatfield in Hertfordshire, although Stag Lane was retained for engine manufacture.

During World War II de Havilland produced two very different aircraft that were both to play an important role for the RAF. The Tiger Moth became the RAF's principal basic trainer, while the Mosquito was probably the world's first true multirole aircraft, as it was eventually used for myriad tasks, including as a fighter, night-fighter, fighter-bomber, bomber, and reconnaissance craft.

